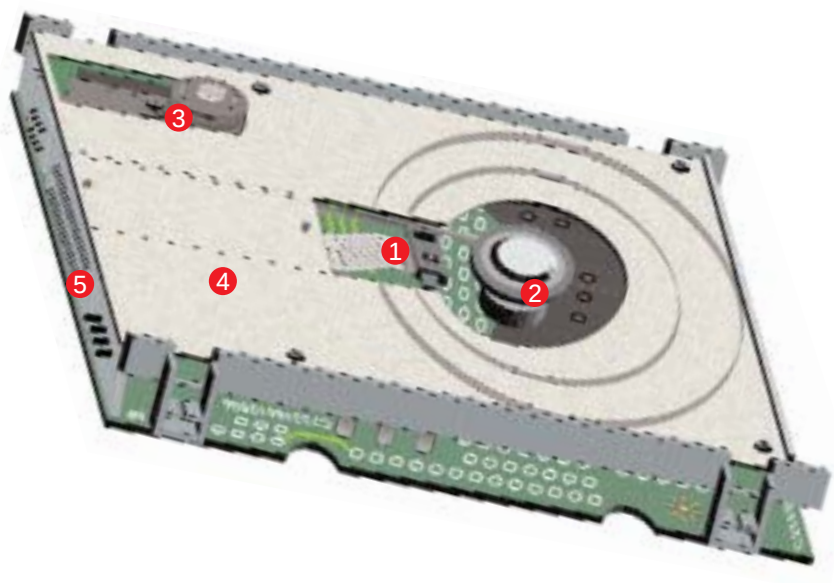




Buying Tips

- ✓ **FORMATS AVAILABLE:** DVD burners are available in different formats. Some drives have adopted a single format, while other drives are available in dual formats. Currently, there are six recordable versions of DVDs, out of which four are prevalent in the Indian market.
- ✓ **COMPATIBILITY WITH A STANDARD DVD PLAYER:** When buying a DVD burner, make sure that you are settling for a format that is widely accepted, and can be accessed by different drives. For example, DVD-RAM media is incompatible with standalone DVD players, and is hence not recommended if you want to backup movies to watch on a DVD player later.
- ✓ **COMPATIBILITY WITH OTHER FORMATS:** It is highly recommended that you opt for a burner that is compatible with all the existing formats available in the market, to ensure that your writer does not become obsolete in a relatively short period of time. Buying a DVD writer that supports only one format will be a bad investment as the '+' and '-' formats are incompatible with each other.
- ✓ **INTERNAL VS EXTERNAL:** If you are a systems administrator who regularly shuffles from one office to another, then an external DVD writer is recommended. These are more expensive than their IDE counterparts, but the functionality remains the same. Again opting for a dual-format DVD writer is a good choice.

- ① **Drive lens:** A DVD-ROM has a greater data density than a CD-R. Therefore, the drive lens uses a high intensity laser to read data from such media.
- ② **Disk motor:** This motor controls the rotational speed of the disk. These have high spin speeds.
- ③ **Tracking motor:** This motor takes care of the laser assembly and makes it read data from the inner to the outer tracks on the DVD.
- ④ **Drive tray:** It's the tray in which you place the DVD. Some drives feature a slot interface, thereby doing away with the tray.
- ⑤ **Connectors:** The IDE and power connectors are placed at the back of the drive.

Quick Find

YOU NEED	To backup movies
Basic Use	
LOOK FOR	A DVD media format and writer that is compatible with standalone DVD players.
YOU NEED	Primarily, data backup
Inter Use	
LOOK FOR	Any format DVD writer will do. Future-proof solutions would be a good bet
YOU NEED	You are on the move and data backup is your responsibility
Prof Use	
LOOK FOR	External dual-format DVD writers are the way to go

Do Remember

- Check if the software supplied with the writer is compatible with your OS. Also make sure that there are regular updates available from the software publisher at their Web site.
- Check the warranty offered by the drive manufacturer. Visit Web sites and gather information about the particular drive that you are interested in before making your decision. Make sure that the drive manufacturer has a good presence in the market and will provide support, if your drive goes kaput.
- Make sure you are purchasing a drive that can write on all types of media. Newer media formats may not work on older DVD writers although manufacturers are trying to resolve this. Opt for a DVD writer that can write DVDs at a speed of at least 8X.



The Future

The future of desktop and SoHo storage is heading towards DVD-writers. These drives are not only able to write on DVD media, but also on CD-Rs and RWs, so you don't need to purchase another drive. These drives will remain at a premium for some time. Once a definite format is established and becomes the norm, the market is bound to flourish, given the enormous amount of data storage space available on a single DVD. Newer technologies such as Blue Ray discs, which are dual-layered and double-sided can hold more than 50 GB of data per DVD, as compared to the current 27 GB per DVD. Normal DVD±R media can back up about 4.3 GB of data per DVD, but with the finalisation of dual-layered DVDs this capacity will increase to 9 GB per disk. Given these humongous storage capacities, it is only a matter of time before the demand for such drives increases.